

Holyoke's war hero: Talk to honor priest who died tending wounded on D-Day

By Michael Ballway | Special to The Republican | Published: Jun. 05, 2026, 6:21 p.m.

HOLYOKE — An American war hero, a compassionate Catholic priest and a neighbor from the immigrant tenements of Holyoke was celebrated across the Atlantic this week. The Rev. Ignatius P. Maternowski is still remembered and honored in a small town in France where he died trying to help his wounded comrades on D-Day, 82 years ago.

The Rev. James McCurry [hopes Maternowski's story won't be forgotten](#) in Holyoke, either.

"Our men in World War II, they perhaps didn't know what they were facing on D-Day, the horrors of it, but they knew they wanted to help their brothers and sisters in France and the rest of Europe," McCurry said. "Americans always have a generosity of heart, even to heroic, sacrificial actions. That's a lesson that's timeless, isn't it?"

It's a lesson that McCurry hopes residents of Western Massachusetts will want to remember — or hear for the first time. McCurry, who is "semi-retired" from leadership of the Conventual Franciscan province that administers the parish in Holyoke formerly known as Mater Dolorosa, and now as the combined Our Lady of the Cross, will give a free talk about Maternowski at Our Lady of the Cross Church on Thursday, June 11.

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